WEEK 2 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT II

Gallup Q12 and the Practitioner Tradition

What engagement surveys measure, what they predict, and how to adapt them to Indian workplaces.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

DSEH004 · Performance Management and Employee Engagement · M.Com. PGCF 2025 · Exam preparation edition

AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain the origin and evidence base of the Gallup Q12.
- Critique what the Q12 items measure and at what level the evidence holds.
- Compare the Q12, the UWES and Kahn as three ways of seeing engagement.
- Explain measurement invariance and why it matters when adapting a survey.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 2 (apply validated engagement models) and CLO 4 (analyze and interpret engagement data).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

If a survey predicts profit, it must be measuring engagement.

Agree or disagree. What else could it be measuring?

THE PRACTITIONER INSTRUMENT

The Gallup Q12

ORIGIN · BUCKINGHAM AND COFFMAN (1999)

Twelve items distilled from Gallup's research on what distinguishes strong work units and their managers.

EVIDENCE · HARTER ET AL. (2002)

Across 7,939 business units in 36 companies, unit engagement related to customer satisfaction, productivity, profit, turnover and safety.

KEY POINT

The Q12 was built to be actionable by a manager. That design choice explains both its power and its critics.

THE CRITIQUE

What the items actually measure

CONDITIONS, NOT THE STATE

Items such as knowing what is expected describe conditions for engagement, not engagement itself (Macey and Schneider, 2008).

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS

Evidence holds at business unit level. Applying it to individuals risks the ecological fallacy.

CAUSALITY

Longitudinal work suggests perceptions predict later outcomes more than the reverse, though both occur (Harter et al., 2010).

THEORY IN DEPTH · HARTER, SCHMIDT AND HAYES (2002)

Engagement and business outcomes at unit level

THE CORE IDEA

Business units where employees report Q12 conditions perform better on several outcomes.

HOW IT WORKS

A meta analysis across thousands of units linked engagement with customer, productivity, profit, turnover and safety outcomes.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Correlational; the items overlap with satisfaction; data and instrument come from Gallup itself.

IN PRACTICE

A retail chain compares stores: those whose managers clarify expectations and recognize work show lower staff turnover.

EXAM LENS

Cite it for the business case. Then add the critique: unit level, correlational, conditions rather than the state.

THEORY IN DEPTH · MACEY AND SCHNEIDER (2008)

The meaning of employee engagement

THE CORE IDEA

Engagement is used loosely for traits, psychological states and behaviors; these must be kept apart.

HOW IT WORKS

Trait engagement shapes state engagement, which shows in behaviors; conditions at work influence each link.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A conceptual review: it organizes the field rather than testing a single model.

IN PRACTICE

An HR team that reports "engagement" from a survey of working conditions is measuring antecedents, not the state.

EXAM LENS

Use it to define engagement precisely in any answer, and to separate the Q12 from the UWES.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Three instruments, three theories

Instrument	What it measures	Best used for
Gallup Q12	Manager controlled conditions	Unit diagnosis and manager action plans
UWES	The state: vigor, dedication, absorption	Measuring engagement itself
Kahn's conditions	Meaningfulness, safety, availability	Explaining why engagement is absent

EXAM LENS

Choose the instrument by the question: to act, use conditions; to measure, use the state; to explain, use Kahn.

Harter et al. (2002); Schaufeli and Bakker (2004); Kahn (1990)

THEORY IN DEPTH · VANDENBERG AND LANCE (2000)

Does an item mean the same thing everywhere?

THE CORE IDEA

Before comparing groups on a survey, show that items relate to the construct in the same way in each group.

HOW IT WORKS

Measurement invariance is tested in steps: same structure, same loadings, then same intercepts.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Demands large samples and statistical skill that many HR teams lack.

IN PRACTICE

An item on praise from a supervisor may carry different weight in a high power distance plant than in a startup.

EXAM LENS

Use it whenever a question compares regions, generations or countries on survey scores.

Adapting an engagement survey

INDIAN EVIDENCE

Bhatnagar (2007) studied engagement and its link to retention among Indian ITES employees.

TRANSLATION IS NOT ENOUGH

Back translation fixes words; invariance testing checks that meanings match.

LOCAL ITEMS

Add items for context the Q12 omits, such as family responsibilities or shift work.

EXAM TIP

When asked to "design a survey", show the steps: define the construct, choose items, test invariance, plan action.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"The Gallup Q12 measures engagement." Critically evaluate this claim. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains the Q12 and its evidence; uses Macey and Schneider on conditions versus state; discusses level and causality; concludes with a balanced view.

Compare the Q12 with Kahn's three conditions as tools for an Indian manufacturer, and recommend one. **20 marks**

A strong answer: contrasts purpose, level and measurement; addresses cultural adaptation and invariance; justifies the choice.

What is measurement invariance and why does it matter? **10 marks**

A strong answer: defines it; gives the steps; gives an example of a comparison that would mislead without it.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. The Q12 measures conditions a manager can act on, more than engagement itself
2. Its evidence holds at business unit level; do not apply it to individuals
3. Before comparing groups on a survey, show the items mean the same thing

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. (Lesson Plan: Sections I to III.)

Bhatnagar, J. (2007). Talent management strategy of employee engagement in Indian ITES employees: Key to retention. *Employee Relations, 29*(6), 640–663.

Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2017). Job demands–resources theory: Taking stock and looking forward. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 22*(3), 273–285.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 2 set readings. Bhatnagar (2007) is the Indian reading that connects to this lecture.

Sources for this lecture (1 of 3)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Bhatnagar, J. (2007). Talent management strategy of employee engagement in Indian ITES employees: Key to retention. *Employee Relations, 29*(6), 640–663. https://doi.org/10.1108/01425450710826122

Buckingham, M., & Coffman, C. (1999). *First, break all the rules: What the world's greatest managers do differently*. Simon & Schuster.

Harter, J. K., Schmidt, F. L., & Hayes, T. L. (2002). Business unit level relationship between employee satisfaction, employee engagement, and business outcomes: A meta analysis. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 87*(2), 268–279. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.87.2.268

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture (2 of 3)

Harter, J. K., Schmidt, F. L., Asplund, J. W., Killham, E. A., & Agrawal, S. (2010). Causal impact of employee work perceptions on the bottom line of organizations. *Perspectives on Psychological Science, 5*(4), 378–389. https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691610374589

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. https://doi.org/10.2307/256287

Macey, W. H., & Schneider, B. (2008). The meaning of employee engagement. *Industrial and Organizational Psychology, 1*(1), 3–30. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1754-9434.2007.0002.x

Sources for this lecture (3 of 3)

Schaufeli, W. B., & Bakker, A. B. (2004). Job demands, job resources, and their relationship with burnout and engagement: A multi sample study. *Journal of Organizational Behavior, 25*(3), 293–315. https://doi.org/10.1002/job.248

Vandenberg, R. J., & Lance, C. E. (2000). A review and synthesis of the measurement invariance literature: Suggestions, practices, and recommendations for organizational research. *Organizational Research Methods, 3*(1), 4–70. https://doi.org/10.1177/109442810031002